

The StoryDogs Seven-Step Cheat Sheet

Follow one character through connected events, then show what changes.

Use the questions to find ideas and the sentence starters to tell them in order. “Because of that” means the next event grows from what happened before.

Step	StoryDogs question	Story sentence starter
1 	WHO? Who is the story about?	Once upon a time there was ____.
2 	LIFE / WANT What is their ordinary life like, and what do they want?	Every day, ____.
3 	UH-OH! What happens to upset that life?	One day ____.
4 	TROUBLE What problem do they face because of that?	Because of that, ____.
5 	WORSE! What makes the problem even harder?	Because of that, ____.
6 	CLIMAX What do they do at the biggest, most important moment?	Until finally ____.
7 	CHANGE How are they different afterward?	Ever since then, ____. StoryDogs extension

One important distinction

The first six starters follow Pixar Story Rule #4. “Ever since then, ____” is a StoryDogs extension that shows the character’s change. It is not part of Pixar’s original rule.

Optional vocabulary for Grades 4-6

Story term	Where it fits
Protagonist	WHO? The main character we follow.
Conflict	UH-OH! and TROUBLE: the problem and what stands in the way.
Rising action	TROUBLE and WORSE!: connected events make the problem harder.
Climax	CLIMAX: the biggest moment and the character’s important action.
Resolution	CHANGE: what settles afterward and how the character is different.

Terms are optional. Students can build a strong story in everyday language.